

General Knowledge

Ancient History

STUDY NOTES

Later Vedic Period



Later Vedic Period

INTRODUCTION:

- The **Later Vedic Period**, spanning from **1000 BCE** to **600 BCE**, marks a significant evolution from the **Early Vedic Period**.
- During this phase, the **Aryan tribes** expanded their territory from the **Sapta Sindhu** region into the Gangetic plains, leading to a more structured society, complex political institutions, and changes in religious beliefs.

The Vedic texts that belong to this period include:

1. **Sama Veda**
2. **Yajur Veda**
3. **Atharva Veda**
4. **Brahmanas**
5. **Aranyakas**
6. **Upanishads**

Aryan Theory:

- The term **Aryan** originates from the Sanskrit word 'Arya' in origin.
- These people called Aryans after their language.
- The original home of the Aryans is a debatable question and there are several views.
- Different scholars have identified different regions as the original home of the Aryans.
- These theories are:
 - **European Theory- By Sir William Jones**
 - **Central Asian Theory – By Max Muller**
 - **Arctic Region Theory- B.G.Tilak**
 - **Indian Theory- By Dr. Sampurnanand, A.C. Das (Saptsindhu region), Pandit**
 - **Laxmidhar Shastri (Foot of Himalayas) and Pandit Ganganath Jha (Brahma rishi Desh)**
 - **Tibet Theory- By Swami Dayanand Saraswati**
 - **Pamir Plateau- Edward Mayor**

Religion of Vedic Aryans:

- The religion of early Vedic Aryans was primarily Worship of **nature** and **Yajnas**.
- The **Bhakti movement** originated in India during the **seventh** to eighth century AD.
- The Vedic **Aryans** did not follow idol worship.



Key Aspects of the Later Vedic Period (1000 BCE - 600 BCE):

Aspect	Details
Sources of Information	Sama Veda, Yajur Veda, Atharva Veda, Brahmanas, Aranyakas, and Upanishads
Political Structure	Rise of large kingdoms (Mahajanapadas); kingship becomes hereditary and more powerful, decline of tribal assemblies like Sabha and Samiti.
Economic Structure	Shift towards agriculture as the main occupation. Use of iron implements, expansion of trade, and increased production.
Social Structure	Clear stratification of the Varna system (Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas, and Shudras). Increasing rigidity in the caste system.
Religion	Elaborate rituals and sacrifices (Ashvamedha, Rajasuya). Evolution of philosophical ideas like karma, dharma, and moksha in the Upanishads.
Language and Literature	Transition from Vedic Sanskrit to more refined forms of Sanskrit. Oral tradition continues, with philosophical debates gaining prominence.
Women's Role	Gradual decline in the status of women. Patriarchal control increases, though some women still participate in religious rituals.
Trade and Exchange	Trade expands, the barter system continues, with the gradual introduction of coinage towards the end of this period.
Warfare and Weapons	The use of iron weapons has become common. Armies include horse-drawn chariots, archers, and foot soldiers.
Philosophical Developments	Upanishads laid the foundation for Indian philosophy. Concepts like Brahman (universal soul) and Atman (individual soul) gain importance.

Political Structure:

Aspect	Details
Type of Rule	Kingship became hereditary, marking the shift from tribal chiefs to monarchs with centralized power. The title of Rajan (king) was passed down through lineage.
Rise of Janapadas	Janapadas (smaller kingdoms or territories) emerged as the basic political units. These were often formed around tribes that settled into specific geographic areas.
Mahajanapadas Formation	By the end of this period, Mahajanapadas (large kingdoms) emerged from Janapadas , each ruled by a powerful king. These formed the foundation for early Indian states.
Role of Rajan (King)	The Rajan (king) held supreme authority, overseeing administration, law, and order. He was supported by a council of advisors (purohita, senani, and others). The king's legitimacy was often reinforced through elaborate rituals like the Ashvamedha Yajna (horse sacrifice).
Assemblies' Decline	Sabha and Samiti , which had significant roles in the Early Vedic Period, began to lose importance as kingship centralized power. The king became more autocratic, and the role of these assemblies became largely ceremonial.
Important Ministers	- Purohita: The chief priest who performed sacrifices and advised the king on religious matters. - Senani: The commander of the army. - Gramini: Village headman, often a military leader in earlier periods.
Judicial System	Kings held judicial authority, but the Sabha still had some role in legal matters. Crimes were punished based on Vedic law, and social order was maintained through the Varna system.
Wars and Conquests	Wars were primarily fought to expand territory, gain control of resources (especially cattle and fertile land), and assert dominance over neighboring tribes. Kings often conducted military campaigns to consolidate power.
Sacrificial Rituals	Sacrifices like the Ashvamedha Yajna and Rajasuya were performed to demonstrate the king's supremacy and divine favor. These rituals also reinforced the king's control over his subjects.
Shift to Territorial Control	The focus shifted from a tribal society based on kinship to a more territorial form of governance, where control over land and resources became the primary source of power.
Expansion of Territory	Aryan expansion into the Gangetic plains was a major development during this period, leading to the foundation of larger, more permanent kingdoms. This marked the end of a nomadic lifestyle for many.
Role of Brahmins	Brahmins gained considerable political influence, acting as advisors to the king and conducting religious ceremonies that legitimized the king's rule. Their power increased as they controlled religious and political functions.
Symbol of Kingship	Kings were seen as the protectors of Dharma (righteousness) and often compared to gods. Titles like Samrat (universal ruler) and Chakravartin (emperor) were used.

emerged to signify the king's dominance.

Political Organization:

- The political structure of the Later Vedic period underwent significant changes from the early pastoral societies of the Rig Vedic period to more settled agricultural societies.
- The nature of kingship, the evolution of large kingdoms, and the organization of governance became more complex.

Key Features of Political Organization:

- Emergence of Larger Kingdoms:** The smaller tribal units, which were known as Jana in the Early Vedic period, expanded into larger territorial units called **Mahajanapadas** during this period.
- The most prominent kingdoms were **Kuru**, **Panchala**, **Kosala**, and **Videha**. These kingdoms were located in the **Gangetic plains**, indicating the **Aryan** expansion eastward.

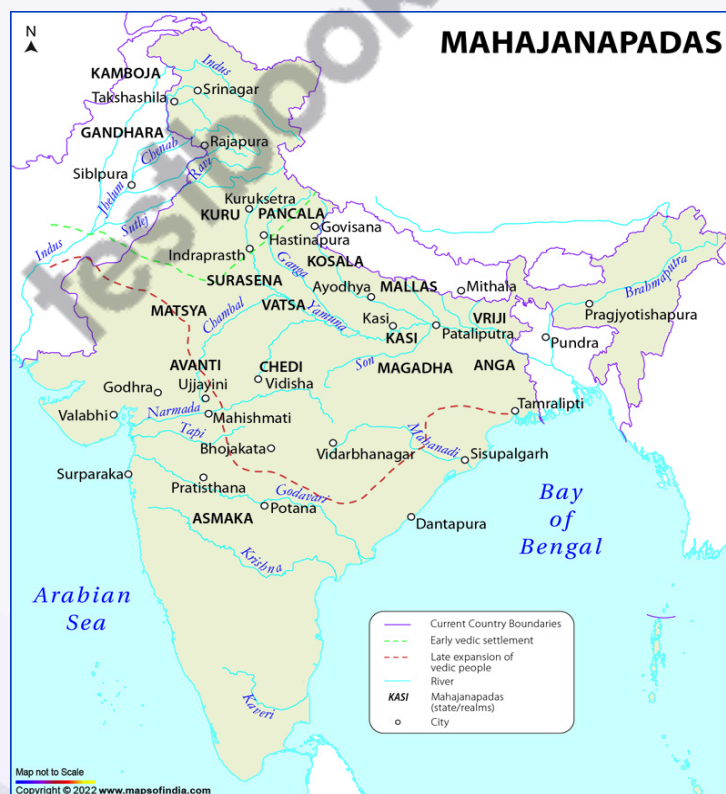
The 16 Mahajanapadas:

Mahajanapada	Location (Modern Regions)	Capital
Anga	Parts of present-day Bihar and West Bengal	Champa
Magadha	Southern Bihar	Rajagriha (later Pataliputra)
Vajji (Vriji)	Northern Bihar, around Vaishali	Vaishali
Malla	Parts of present-day Uttar Pradesh	Kusinagara and Pava
Kashi	Around Varanasi (Uttar Pradesh)	Varanasi
Kosala	Modern-day Uttar Pradesh (Ayodhya and surrounding areas)	Shravasti
Vatsa (Vamsa)	Parts of modern-day Uttar Pradesh (near Allahabad)	Kaushambi
Kuru	Present-day Haryana and Delhi	Indraprastha
Panchala	Parts of Uttar Pradesh	Ahichhatra (North) and Kampilya (South)
Matsya	Parts of Rajasthan (around Jaipur, Alwar)	VirataNagara
Chedi	Bundelkhand region (parts of Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh)	Suktimati
Surasena	Around Mathura (Uttar Pradesh)	Mathura
Assaka (Ashmaka)	Located in the Deccan, along the Godavari River (Maharashtra/Andhra Pradesh)	Pratishthana
Avanti	Western Madhya Pradesh	Ujjayini (North) and Mahishmati (South)

Gandhara	Modern-day Pakistan and Afghanistan (Peshawar and surrounding areas)	Taxila
Kamboja	Parts of Afghanistan and northern Pakistan	Rajapura

Key Features of the Mahajanapadas:

- **Monarchical and Republican Systems:** Some Mahajanapadas, like Magadha, Kosala, and Kuru, were monarchies where kings wielded absolute power. Others, like Vajji and Malla, were republics (**Gana-sanghas**) where governance was more oligarchic, with decisions made by assemblies of elders or elected representatives.
- **Political Rivalry:** Several **Mahajanapadas** engaged in warfare for territorial expansion and dominance.
 - The Magadha empire eventually rose to prominence under rulers like Bimbisara and Ajatashatru, annexing several other Mahajanapadas, and laying the foundation for future Indian empires.
- **Economic Prosperity:** Many of these **Mahajanapadas** had fertile lands, thriving trade routes, and growing urban centers.
 - This contributed to their wealth and power. Cities like Varanasi, Rajagriha, and Ujjayini became important cultural and economic hubs.



Later Vedic Period Administration and Social Structure:

- **Kingship (Raja):** The king (Raja) emerged as a more powerful figure, with the early Vedic tribal chieftain transitioning into a hereditary monarch.
- The king claimed to be the divinely ordained protector of his people and territory. The king's authority was supported by elaborate rituals, which were performed to legitimize his rule, particularly the Rajasuya (royal consecration) and the **Ashvamedha Yajna** (horse sacrifice).
- **Administrative Setup:** The later Vedic administration became more organized. Officials such as the Senani (army chief), Purohita (chief priest), and Gramini (village headman) assisted the king. A new official, the Sangrahitri (treasurer), emerged, reflecting the growing importance of revenue collection.

Assemblies (Sabha and Samiti):

- **Sabha and Samiti**, the popular assemblies, played a lesser role compared to the earlier Vedic times, as **kingship** became more centralized. The **Sabha** functioned as a council of the elite and aristocrats, while the Samiti was a general assembly that represented the common people. However, their influence diminished as kings became more **autocratic**.
- **Wars and Expansion:** Warfare was an important activity during the Later Vedic period. Conflicts among the kingdoms for the control of fertile territories were common. The **Ratnin** (jewel-bearers), or **nobles** who contributed to the war efforts, gained prominence during this time.

Society and Social Structure

- The social organization in the Later Vedic period became more stratified, leading to a complex, hierarchical structure that laid the foundation for the caste system in India.
- **Key Features of Social Structure:**
 - Varna System: The stratification of society into four main Varnas became rigid:
 - **Brahmins:** Priests and scholars who conducted rituals, sacrifices, and education. They held the highest social status.
 - **Kshatriyas:** Warriors and rulers who were responsible for governance and protection of the realm.
 - **Vaishyas:** Merchants, farmers, and traders. They engaged in agriculture, animal husbandry, and trade, playing a crucial role in the economy.
 - **Shudras:** The laboring class. Their primary role was to serve the other three Varnas. They had very limited rights and were excluded from most social and religious privileges.
- Intermarriage between Varnas was discouraged, and endogamy became the norm.
- Patriarchy: The society was predominantly patriarchal. The eldest male member was the head of the family (Grihapati).
- Women's position deteriorated compared to the Early Vedic period. Their participation in public life was reduced, and child marriage, although not widespread, was practiced among certain sections.
- Gotra System: The concept of gotra (clan) emerged, particularly among the Brahmins and Kshatriyas, to ensure lineage purity.

- Gotra was inherited from the father, and marriage within the same gotra was forbidden (to prevent inbreeding).
- Ashrama System: Life was divided into four stages (Ashramas)—Brahmacharya (student life), Grihastha (householder life), Vanaprastha (retired life), and Sannyasa (renounced life).
- This division emphasized a structured, disciplined approach to life in religious and societal terms, but it was largely applicable to upper-caste males.

Religion and Philosophy

- The religious system became more elaborate and ritualistic in the Later Vedic period. However, at the same time, philosophical inquiries into the nature of existence began to develop.

Key Religious Practices:

- **Ritualism and Sacrifices:** Religion during this period was dominated by complex rituals and sacrifices (Yajnas).
- The rituals were performed to gain the favor of the gods and to bring material success, fertility, and political power. Sacrifices like:
 - **Rajasuya:** Performed to inaugurate a king.
 - **Ashvamedha:** A horse sacrifice to assert the king's dominance.
 - **Vajapeya:** Conducted by Kshatriyas to establish their superiority.

These rituals consolidated the power of the Brahmins, who became the custodians of religious knowledge.

- **Deities:** The pantheon of gods shifted. While Indra, Agni, and Varuna were prominent in the early Vedic period.
- In the later period, **Vishnu** and **Rudra** (Shiva) gained importance. The concepts of **dharma** (duty) and **karma** (action and its consequences) also became significant.

Philosophical Development:

- **Upanishads:** The Later Vedic period witnessed the composition of the Upanishads, which moved away from ritualistic practices and focused on spiritual and philosophical inquiries.
- The central concepts of Brahman (the ultimate reality) and Atman (the individual soul) were discussed in depth. The Upanishads laid the foundation for the later schools of Hindu philosophy (Vedanta).
- Concepts of Karma and Moksha: Karma, the idea of action and its consequences, and Moksha, the liberation from the cycle of birth and rebirth, became central to the Upanishadic thought. These ideas marked a shift from the earlier ritualistic Vedic religion towards introspective spiritualism.

Economy:

- The economic structure of the Later Vedic society became more agrarian, but trade and crafts also flourished.

Key Economic Features:

- **Agriculture:** Agriculture became the dominant economic activity. The use of iron tools (iron was referred to as Krishna Ayas) led to the clearing of dense

forests, particularly in the Gangetic plains, allowing for extensive agricultural activities.

- Wheat, barley, rice, and pulses were cultivated. The practice of irrigation was limited but growing.
- **Animal Husbandry:** Cattle continued to be a crucial asset, and wealth was often measured in terms of the number of cows. Horses were valued for warfare, and cattle raids were common in conflicts.
- **Crafts and Pottery:** The Painted Grey Ware (PGW) culture marked this period.
- This type of pottery was produced in large quantities and has been found at several Later Vedic sites. Black and red pottery were also used.
- **Trade:** Trade became more organized, both internal and external. Barter was still the dominant system, though there is some evidence of early forms of currency, such as metal tokens (nishka).
- Trade routes, particularly those connecting northern India to Central Asia, became more significant.

Education and Literature

- Education during the Later Vedic period was largely religious and oral, but new forms of intellectual thought also emerged.

Key Aspects of Education:

- **Vedic Schools (Gurukulas):** Education was imparted through oral traditions. Brahmin students (Brahmacharis) were taught in Gurukulas by a Guru. They were trained in the memorization and recitation of Vedic texts, along with their explanations.
- **Vedic Texts:** The four Vedas were expanded with the composition of the Sama Veda, Yajur Veda, and Atharva Veda. Commentaries on these Vedas, called Brahmanas, were composed to explain the significance of rituals.
- **Upanishads:** The Upanishads formed the philosophical basis of the Vedic tradition, with an emphasis on metaphysical questions. They rejected the ritualism of the Brahmanas and focused on meditation, ethics, and self-realization.

End of the Later Vedic Period:

- By 600 BCE, the Later Vedic period gave way to the rise of the Mahajanapadas and the age of urbanization.
- Kingdoms consolidated into more powerful states, leading to the formation of large city-states like Magadha.
- The rigid caste system, the rise of new philosophical thought (leading to the rise of Jainism and Buddhism), and the political transformations set the stage for the later classical age of Indian civilization.

Aspect	Later Vedic Period (1000 BCE - 600 BCE)	End of the Period (600 BCE)
--------	---	-----------------------------

Political Structure	Small kingdoms, tribal chieftainships, and Janapadas	Emergence of large Mahajanapadas; Rise of centralized monarchies like Magadha
Kingship	Hereditary kingship; Ritualistic support (Rajasuya, Ashvamedha)	Kingship strengthened with standing armies, bureaucratic administration
Assemblies	Sabha and Samiti exist but diminishing in power	Popular assemblies diminished; Monarchical power grew
Social Structure	Varna system becoming rigid; Patriarchy strengthened	Caste divisions were further entrenched; Endogamy was practiced, and Brahmins dominant
Religion	Focus on ritual sacrifices (Yajnas); Polytheism with deities like Indra, Agni	Rise of philosophical inquiry (Upanishads); Focus on Karma, Dharma, and Moksha
Philosophy	Emphasis on rituals and sacrifices for material prosperity	Birth of Upanishadic philosophy; Spiritual quest for Brahman (ultimate reality) and Atman (soul)
Economy	Agriculture-based; Use of iron tools; Cattle wealth; Barter system	Agricultural expansion into the Gangetic plains; Growth in trade routes, early coinage systems
Urbanization	Semi-urban settlements, the gradual shift from pastoralism	The emergence of urban centers like Pataliputra, Varanasi, Rajagriha
Education	Gurukul system; Oral transmission of Vedic texts	Composition of Upanishads and Sutras; Focus on metaphysical and ethical education
End of Period	Expansion into the Gangetic plains; Rise of larger states	Mahajanapadas consolidated power; Magadha became dominant